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and circumstance that go back to the 18th century for some regiments, India today has the second largest military in the world, with 1.4 million personnel and 960,000 reserves. The Indian military has fought four wars against Pakistan, including the 1999 border conflict in Kargil.

In 1962, it faced the People's Republic of China in the heights of Ladakh and what was then NEFA (North East Frontier Areas). India's navy and air force also have a history that stretches back to the colonial period. The Indian Air Force (IAF) was established in 1932, and after Independence, it retained seven fighter squadrons and other aircraft of the Royal Indian Air Force. The IAF has close to 170,000 personnel, with some 900 combat-capable planes, including the indigenous Tejas LCA (light combat aircraft) and the Rafale multirole fighter. Though struggling with its depleting fleet, it is ranked third in the world air power index. The Indian navy has a personnel strength of 80,000, with 150 vessels and 300 aircraft. India's first indigenous aircraft carrier, the 45,000 tonne INS Vikrant, has been handed over to the navy. India also has 15 conventional submarines, and INS Arihant, a nuclear-powered submarine. ■

India's military expenditure of $76.6 billion in 2021 was the third highest in the world

With over 1.4 million active personnel, it's the world's second-largest military force

The Indian Army plans to bring down its strength from 1.28 million to around 1.08 million in the next two years

MILESTONES

1947-48
War for Kashmir: Pakistani army regulars and tribal raiders invade Kashmir. Over 15,000 troops fight on both sides. UN draws ceasefire line between India and Pakistan

1961
Operation Vijay: Portuguese India (Goa, Daman, and Diu) is incorporated into India

JUNE 1961
HAL HF-24 Marut: India's first indigenous fighter-bomber aircraft takes flight

1962
Indo-China War: Dispute over McMahon Line has nearly 20,000 Indian troops fight 80,000 Chinese soldiers in Ladakh, NEFA. 6,000-odd casualties

1965
Indo-Pak War: Over 33,000 Pakistani soldiers posing as locals enter Kashmir. Indian military responds strongly via a second front. UN-negotiated ceasefire

1967
Kalvari-class: India inducts its first submarines from USSR and renames them

1971
Indo-Pak War: Indian military defeats Pakistan, to liberate Bangladesh. Over 90,000 PoWs taken

1986
Bofors deal: India signs deal with Swedish firm AB Bofors for 400 howitzer guns. They play a key role in the 1999 Kargil conflict

1987
Operation Pawan: Indian Peace Keeping Force deployed to take control of Jaffna and enforce disarmament of LTTE as part of Indo-Lankan Accord

1989
Agni I: India's first intercontinental ballistic missile, with a range of 700-1,200 km, tested. More sophisticated versions tested in following decades

1999
Kargil conflict: Pakistani soldiers and Kashmiri militants occupy key heights in Kargil. Indian army launches Op Vijay and IAF Op Safed Sagar to oust them

2016
Rafale deal: India signs deal with French firm Dassault to buy 36 Rafale multirole fighter jets, of which 35 have been delivered

2016
Arihant-class: The made in India nuclear-powered ballistic submarines commissioned

2020
Doklam: Border clashes between Indian army and PLA in Ladakh lead to military stand-off. Complete disengagement still awaited despite 16 rounds of talks